

Weinberg, F.J. (2026). *Mentorship: Empowering Mentees to Take the Lead and Co-Create their Development*. Toronto, Canada: Rotman-UTP Publishing, University of Toronto Press. 330 pages. ISBN: 978-1-0498-0063-9. Price: USD \$35.14 (hardcover).

Reviewed by: Engin Tuncer (<https://orcid.org/0009-0003-3163-3601>), PhD Candidate, Global Leadership, Indiana Institute of Technology, USA; Quality Manager, Lyten Inc.

Professionals do not grow into leaders the way they used to. Organisations have fewer levels of hierarchy. Careers have fewer guarantees, and work experience no longer automatically confers authority. Hybrid work, fast career turnover, and new generations entering formal organisations have brought one question back into focus: who owns professional development? And yet, despite 50 years of mentoring research, one belief has gone mostly unexamined: that mentoring means the mentor is in charge and the mentee takes direction. This critical assumption needs a deep dive.

The picture described above needs more clarification. To take a close look at the picture, an organisational approach is needed. Today's organizations have higher expectations than just the return on the shareholders' investment. Leadership is widely spread in organizations and, therefore, one's willingness to take charge of one's own development assumes an institutional significance, not merely an individual benefit. Mentoring is an organisational process with consequences for talent management, succession, and the success of the learning organization.

Frankie J. Weinberg's *Mentorship: Empowering Mentees to Take the Lead and Co-Create their Development*; challenges researchers and practitioners to look at mentoring from a unique perspective. Published through Rotman School of Business Press at the University of Toronto, Weinberg (2026) argues that mentees should own their development and that mentors should learn how to support, rather than lead.

Weinberg's central claim is simple enough to read but uncomfortable to digest at first: that mentoring should be mentee-led. This runs counter to the default assumption that wisdom flows downward from the more experienced person. Weinberg argues that the assumption is precisely what makes most mentoring programs underperform. When mentees surrender control, they lose the agency that makes any of it meaningful.

The book has been driven by the core metaphor that the mentee is the captain, and the mentor is the navigator. The captain decides where to go. The navigator reads the conditions, suggests corrections, and helps to navigate in uncharted waters. That division of authority is not just a conversational frame; it restructures how programs are designed. Organizations need to consider who bears responsibility for talent development, while leaders may at times need to take a meaningful pause (Chess, 2021).

Weinberg organizes the whole approach around the ACE Framework: Align, Collaborate, Evolve. Each stage begins with the mentee. Alignment is internal work that you need to be clear on your own values and direction before you involve anyone else.

Collaboration extends that outward through dialogue. Evolving means both parties keep adjusting as things change.

Sitting alongside ACE are the Seven C's: Coachability, Connection, Co-Creation, Capital, Cultivation, Courage, and Competence. Weinberg is careful not to position these as entry requirements but as ongoing capacities. Combined, the two frameworks define what he calls authentic mentoring.

Rather than summarizing every chapter, this section focuses on four that best show what the book does well — and where it leaves things unfinished.

Aligning Foundations (Chapter 1) opens with the book's central paradox: the mentoring journey begins not with finding a mentor but with understanding yourself. Weinberg's argument is that mentees arrive at these relationships underprepared more often than anyone admits — without real clarity on their goals, and without honest self-assessment about how well they take feedback. Coachability is the foundational competency, distinguished from obedience, framed as a growth mindset applied to mentorship. The Tesla–Edison and Jobs–Noyce case studies work as counterpoints. Tesla's story matters because it complicates the framework: coachability cannot save a mentee from a mentor who misreads their developmental stage. Weinberg sees the tension. He does not fully resolve it. The Self-Alignment Map is the most immediately usable tool in the chapter. For professionals crossing industries or stepping into new cultural environments, the push to do inner work before looking outward is grounded and useful.

Charting New Courses (Chapter 5) covers the phase that gets least attention: when a working relationship needs to change to stay relevant. Weinberg takes on three assumptions — that mentoring relationships are fixed, that mentors hold the answers, and that seniority means fit. The contrast between Edsel Ford's stunted development under his father and Irène Joliot-Curie's deliberate restructuring of her relationship with Marie Curie is one of the preview copy's stronger narrative moments. What the chapter gets right is its willingness to say that familiarity and safety can become obstacles — that the comfort of an established relationship can quietly prevent both parties from growing. The critique of rigid formal programs lands. What it does not address is how recalibration works when the power gap makes that conversation professionally risky for the mentee.

Chapter 6 addresses the phase almost no mentoring literature bothers with: the ending. Weinberg's argument is that separation is a growth milestone, one that should be led deliberately rather than allowed to fade out. The quiet assumption — that longer always means better — is what he thinks distorts how organisations design programmes in the first place. The

Syd Barrett and Roger Waters case study illustrates what goes wrong without a shared narrative of closure: one person stalls, the other moves on, and neither quite names what happened. The Colbert–Stewart example runs the other direction — a transition managed well enough to preserve the relationship and leave both parties somewhere useful. The chapter pulls all Seven Cs into a single arc, and it does not feel like a checklist exercise. The willingness to treat endings as emotionally real, rather than just administratively inconvenient, is where the book earns some of its credibility.

Chapter 7 closes the ACE cycle by looking at what happens after the formal relationship ends. Weinberg's decision to omit a Shipwreck case study here is worth noting — by this point in the book, he seems to trust readers to apply the framework themselves rather than follow another worked example. The Gates–French Gates choice is risky: prominent, contested, and open to readings Weinberg does not fully control. It still works. The Seven C's integration into a re-entry framework is the most developed theoretical section in the preview copy — tighter than earlier chapters, less reliant on the case material to carry the argument.

The "admiral" concept is where the nautical metaphor finally pays off. The seasoned mentee is no longer in one developmental relationship but managing several simultaneously, each at a different stage. That shift — from mentee to coordinator of one's own network — raises organisational questions the book does not have space to answer. Someone probably should.

Mentorship earns its place. The theoretical architecture holds the ACE Framework and the Seven C's work as a unified model rather than a collection of standalone tools, which is rarer than it should be in this literature. That coherence also makes the book transferable to organisational learning programmes, not just personal reading. The adult learning design is worth noting: the Captain's Log reflections (Weinberg, 2026) Beacon and Shipwreck narratives, and chapter toolkits reflect a genuine understanding of how adults learn through experience, reflection, and application rather than passive absorption.

There are a few limitations, the most significant being a cultural gap. Weinberg's model is built on individual agency, self-determination, and direct communication — values that sit comfortably in low-power-distance, Western professional settings (Hofstede, 2001; Hofstede et al., 2010). In high power-distance cultures across Asia, the Middle East, and parts of Europe, deference to senior figures is not a habit to be

coached away; it is a social norm with real professional consequences (Hofstede et al., 2010). A mentee in those environments who tries to lead and redirect the relationship may not find empowerment on the other side. They may meet pushback, confusion, or damaged standing. The book gestures at adaptability but does not give those mentees anything concrete. For a work with global ambitions, this is a real gap.

The second limitation is assigned mentoring. Weinberg's model assumes the mentee entered the relationship with some degree of intention. Most corporate mentoring does not work that way. HR departments pair people, managers track completion, and the relationship continues regardless of whether the mentee sought it out. "Take the lead" is considerably harder to act on in that context than the book lets on.

The assumed baseline of self-awareness is a related problem. The captain-navigator metaphor works for professionals who already know where they want to go. For early-career individuals who have never been asked to articulate a professional destination, it may not land in the same way. Before someone can captain a voyage, they need to understand that a destination is required. The Self-Alignment Map addresses this in principle, but the surrounding narrative assumes a reader already oriented toward self-direction. Practitioners collaborating with new graduates will likely find the foundational exercises need more scaffolding than the text allows for.

Third, the case studies are drawn almost entirely from Western contexts and well-known public figures. The Tesla–Edison, Jobs–Noyce, and Gates–French Gates examples are recognisable and effective, but they will feel remote to readers outside North American and European professional settings. Non-Western mentoring traditions deserve space in a book making global claims.

Finally, the sheer volume of tools, prompts, and frameworks risks overwhelming practitioners who need focused, immediately usable guidance. A clearer signal about which tools are essential versus supplementary would help without reducing the book's depth.

It helps to read *Mentorship* next to recent work in the same vein, to crystallize what it gets right and what it takes for granted. Garvey and Stokes's (2022) fourth edition, also taking stock of a field of practice that is pluralistic, takes up coaching and

mentoring across several continents and gives more sustained attention to issues of discourse, power, and contextual conditions as necessary, if insufficient, parts of any developmental relationship. Read against that backdrop, Weinberg's contribution is narrower, but also more vulnerable: his single, powerfully argued thesis, of mentee-led development, is sharpened by its narrowness but omits relational power dynamics which Garvey and Stokes take as central — precisely the element that this review identified as not well-examined in the captain-navigator model. The omission stands out, in turn, against Kumar and Budhwar's (2020) edited volume on mentoring across China, India, Korea, Taiwan, and beyond, where the high power distance of those societies routinely casts the mentor in a paternalistic role and deference from the protégé is a matter of social expectation rather than an optional, coachable style. Their work, in other words, shows that the cultural limitation outlined in this review is not a mere hypothetical objection but an existing body of scholarship that Weinberg's Western, individual-agency based approach bypasses.

These concerns connect to a conversation already underway in this journal. Ahuja and Yadav (2023) show, in a study of 289 Indian academics, that a leader's influence on follower motivation runs through an enabling condition — in their case, training toward inclusion — rather than operating directly; the parallel to Weinberg is instructive, since his model likewise assumes that the enabling conditions for mentee agency are simply present rather than deliberately built. Where Weinberg asks the mentee to captain the voyage, this line of work is a reminder that someone must first supply the chart and the harbor. Kumar's (2023) interview on young men in crisis reinforces the point from the mentor's side: it describes developmental relationships in which the older figure's task is to listen, to ask, and to help a younger person articulate values and a sense of direction — the same supportive, non-directive posture Weinberg advocates, but grounded in the messy realities of identity, isolation, and readiness that his framework tends to hold constant. Situated among these texts, *Mentorship* is best understood not as a comprehensive account of mentoring but as a deliberately bounded intervention — one that advances the conversation on mentee agency while leaving its cross-cultural, power-sensitive, and developmental extensions to the very scholarship these comparators represent.

Mentorship is written for a broad audience and mostly earns that scope. The most natural readers are people at genuine turning points: early-career professionals, graduate students navigating advisor relationships, new managers, seasoned professionals in career transition. For all of them, the book offers concrete tools rather than abstract encouragement; the Self-Alignment Map, the Mentorship Charter, the Transition Readiness Scan, and the Captain's Log reflections, among others (Weinberg, 2026). Holding the framework together across career stages is harder than it looks, and Weinberg mostly manages it.

Mentors and senior leaders will find things here too, despite the book being written squarely from the mentee's side. Reframing the mentor as navigator rather than authority asks experienced professionals to reconsider what they are actually doing in that role. It has direct implications for how organisations design development programmes, onboard new talent, and build something that functions as a learning culture rather than just a learning calendar. HR professionals and organisational learning practitioners will find the architecture compatible with existing leadership development work without requiring a wholesale redesign.

The book carries particular urgency in fast-moving, resource-constrained environments such as technology startups, early-stage research, and doctoral programs. In those settings, formal development infrastructure is often absent, and individuals have to take ownership of their own growth, whether they planned to or not. Weinberg's argument lands differently there than it would inside a large, well-resourced organisation. Not every book works as both a personal resource and an organisational one. This one does.

To sum up, *Mentorship: Empowering Mentees to Take the Lead and Co-Create their Development* is a well-prepared book that adds to the current literature. Organizations can adopt the approach that is not just theoretical but practical as well. The book's general usage is very close to the audience, and the language is natural, so readers will not feel as if they are in a different world. On the other hand, the book and research itself are substantive enough for academic and institutional use. The modular design allows self-contained chapters to be picked independently rather than needing to read straight through. Integrated frameworks used are structural models that guide readers' thinking deeply or prompt action. Reflective tools make the book versatile enough to serve three different audiences: personal development, corporate

onboarding, and higher education. Few books in this space do all three without losing coherence somewhere along the way.

People manage their own career paths and make their own moves rather than following employees' forced tracks. Companies have fewer layers of hierarchy, so there is almost no structure guiding people upward. Professional identities are now your brand shapes, shaped by your choices. Weinberg's argument fits that reality. Seeing oneself not as a passenger waiting for direction but as the captain of one's own developmental voyage is a useful reframe. The book changes how we think about mentees' active role by reframing mentee agency. Instead of treating it as a nice-to-have, the book argues it is essential to how mentoring actually functions. With this structure, the book does its most durable work.

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